Having Our Say: The Delaney Sisters' First 100 Years

By Emily Mann

Lights come up slowly on Sadie Delany. She stands straight and tall, addressing the audience.

SADIE: Bessie and I have been together since time began, or so it seems. Bessie is my little sister, only she's not so little. She is 101 years old, and I am 103. *(Bessie enters.)* You know, neither one of us ever married and we've lived together most all of our lives, and probably know each other better than any two human beings on this Earth. After so long, we are in some ways like one person.

BESSIE: How do you do! I'm Dr. Delany. Make yourself comfortable. Stay as long as you like. We won't charge you rent. *(Bessie looks to the audience, eyes fiercely penetrating. They both laugh uproariously)* Truth is, I never thought I'd see the day when people would be interested in what two old Negro women have to say. Life still surprises me. So maybe the last laugh is on me.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Having Our Say:*
ACTRESS 2: *The Delaney Sisters' First 100 Years*
TOGETHER: *by Emily Mann*

SADIE: You know, Bessie and I were in helping professions - she was a dentist and I was a high school teacher -

BESSIE: so we're not rich, but we get by.

SADIE: Papa always taught us that with every dollar you earn, the first ten cents goes to the Lord . . . The second ten cents -

BESSIE: . . . goes in the bank for hard times . . .

SADIE: And the rest is yours, but you better spend it wisely. Well, it's a good thing we listened because we're living on that

BESSIE and SADIE: *(Together.)* hard-time money now,

SADIE: and not doing too badly. We have lived in New York for the last

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seventy-five years, but Raleigh

BESSIE and SADIE: *(Together.)* will always be home.

BESSIE: Raleigh is where Mama and Papa met, as students at Saint Augustine's School,

SADIE: which was a school for Negroes. They got married in the campus chapel and raised all ten of us children right there at -

BESSIE and SADIE: *(Together.)* good old "Saint Aug's."

BESSIE: Papa became vice-principal and Mama was the matron, which meant she ran things day-to-day at the school. Our Papa became the first elected Negro bishop of the Episcopal Church, U.S.A.

SADIE: That's a long way for a man who was born a slave on a Georgia plantation, but if you had known Papa, you wouldn't be surprised. He was always improving himself, and he and Mama brought us up to

BESSIE and SADIE: *(Together.)* reach high.

SADIE: Bessie was what we used to call a "feeling child"; she was sensitive and emotional. She was quick to anger, and very outspoken.

BESSIE: And Sadie was a "mama's child."

SADIE: Yes, I followed my Mama around like a shadow. I always did what I was told. I was calm and agreeable.

BESSIE: She was shy.

SADIE: The way I see it, there's room in the world for both me and Bessie We kind of balance each other out. People learned not to mess with me from Day One.

SADIE: It's a wonder she wasn't lynched.

BESSIE: Well, I almost was, but that's another story. The thing is I know Sadie's going to get into Heaven, but I'm not so sure about me. I'm working on it, but it sure is hard to change.

SADIE: She has trouble with the idea of forgiving and forgetting.

BESSIE: That's right. You see, I can forgive, but I can't seem to forget. And I'm not sure the Lord would approve of that at all. I remember things that happened long, long ago that still make me madder than a hornet. I wish they didn't. Most of the people I'm still mad at are long dead and there are things I can tell you . . . *(She stops herself)* but Sadie will say, "Now Bessie, of the dead -

BESSIE and SADIE: *(Together.)* . . . say nothing Evil."

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BESSIE: So . . . I try to be good. But the rebby boys tend to stand out, make themselves known. You don't know what a rebby boy is.

SADIE: That's what we call white racist men. It's short for rebel.

BESSIE: I'll tell you, the way those rebby types treat colored folks - well, it just makes me sick. Those rebby types don't give colored folks credit for a thing. They learn early to hate. Why, colored folks *built* this country, and that is the truth. We were the laborers, honey! We were the backbone of this country *(She stops herself)* Now, Sadie doesn't get all agitated like this. It's been a little harder for me, partly because I'm darker than she is, and the darker you are, honey, the harder it is. I wish I were more like her but I'm afraid I am a naughty little darky! Ha hal *(Bessie laughs.)* I know it's not fashionable to use some of the words from our heyday, but that's who I am! And who is going to stop me? Nobody, that's who! Ain't nobody going to censor *me,* no sir! I'm a hundred-and-one years old and at my age, honey, I can say what I want! The beginning of Jim Crow in North Carolina was the day that everything Changed.

SADIE: We already knew we were second-class citizens but those Jim Crow laws set it in stone.

BESSIE: At that time, many white people didn't think Negroes had souls. They wanted to believe that.

SADIE: And powerful white people were getting more and more nervous with the way colored people, after the Civil War, were beginning to get their piece of the pie.

BESSIE: The pecking order was like this: white men were the most powerful, followed by white women.

SADIE: Colored people were absolutely below them

BESSIE: and if you think it was hard for colored men, honey, colored women were on the *bottom.* Yes, sir! Colored women took it from all angles! We encountered Jim Crow laws for the first time on a summer Sunday afternoon.

SADIE: We were about five and seven years old at the time. There was a place in Raleigh not just for whites but for the whole city, called Pullen Park. The spring where you got water had a big wooden sign across the middle. *(They gesture with their hands.)*

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BESSIE: On one side, the word "white" was painted,

SADIE: and on the other, the word "colored." What in the world was all this about?

BESSIE: We may have been little children but, honey, we got the message loud and clear.

SADIE: *(Laughing.)* But when nobody was looking, Bessie took the tin dipper and leaned over and scooped some water from the other side and said, "I'm goin' get me some *white* water!"

BESSIE: It tasted just the same. *(They laugh. A beat.)*

SADIE: Yes it did, but I'll tell you how I handled Jim Crow. There was a shoe store in Raleigh called Heller's. The owner was a Jewish man, very nice. If you were colored, you had to go in the back to try on shoes, and the white people sat in the front. It wasn't Mr. Heller's fault; this was the Jim Crow law. I would go in there and say, "Good morning, Mr. Heller, I would like to try on those shoes in the window." And he would say, 'That's fine, Miss Delany, go on and sit in the back." And I would say, "Where, Mr. Heller?" And he would say, "Back there." And I would say, "Back *where?*" Well, I'd just worry that man to death. Finally, he'd say, 'Just sit anywhere, Miss Delany!" And so I would sit myself down in the white section, and smile.

BESSIE: Lord! I hate when you play dumb like that! *(Sadie laughs)* Every time I encountered prejudice which was rubbed in my face under Jim Crow - I would feel it down to my core. *(Very upset.)* The words used to describe us most often were colored, Negro, black, and nigger. I've also been called jiggerboo, pickaninny, coon - you name it, honey. Some of these words are worse than others, and how mean they are depends on who is saying them and why. Personally, I don't use the word black very often to describe myself and my sister. To us, black was a person who was, well, black, and honey, I mean *black as your shoe.* I'm not black, I'm brown! Actually, the best word to describe me, I think, is colored. I am a colored woman or a Negro woman. Either one is OK. People dislike those words now. Today they use this term *African American.* It wouldn't occur to us to use that. We prefer to think of ourselves as Americans, that's all!

SADIE: There was an attitude among some Negroes that to be lighter-skinned

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was more desirable. But it was not something that was even *discussed* in our household. We were different shades, and it didn't make a bit of difference if you were white, black,

BESSIE and SADIE: *(Together.)* grizzly, or gray, you were you.

SADIE: Now Mama and Papa tried to protect us when we were small, but we were quite young when we learned colored folks were being murdered.

BESSIE: They were being lynched.

SADIE: Yes - we would hear the teachers talking among themselves about some poor Negro just walking down the side of the road, in the wrong place, at the wrong time.

BESSIE: Those rebby boys would just grab him and hang him from a tree, just for fun.

SADIE: It was like entertainment to those fellas.

BESSIE: The rebby boys would come in the middle of the night, and get him out of his bed and hang him up, in front of his wife and children. Sometimes they'd hang his whole family. Why, there was one story we heard of a pregnant colored woman who was hung from her feet, and they slit her abdomen open and let the fetus fall out -

SADIE: *(Quietly overlaps Bessie)* Lord have mercy!

BESSIE: and she and her unborn baby just died right there, like that.

SADIE: I don't understand any of this. I sometimes think maybe we were a little too sheltered. Why, I was almost afraid of men, really. I wasn't allowed to go downtown by myself until I was a grown girl and then I was always kind of jittery. You can imagine that when it came time for me to graduate from Saint Aug's, I didn't want to leave. The campus was the only home I'd ever known. But on graduation day, Papa said to me, "Daughter, you are college material. You owe it to your nation, your race, and yourself to go. And if you don't, then shame on you!" Well, it seemed to me that I had no choice but to go on with my schooling. But Papa said to me, to both of us, "Daughters, I have no money, and you mustn't take a scholarship. If you take a scholarship, you will be beholden to the people who gave you the money. You must make your own way." So I started looking for teaching jobs.

BESSIE: When we were teaching, we saw for the first time what life was really like for our people.

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SADIE: Yes, Lord.

BESSIE: It made our hearts bleed.

SADIE: I realized I was a child of privilege and I had to share my good fortune. I kept remembering what Papa always said: ''Your mission . . . "

BESSIE and SADIE: *(Together.)* ". . . is to help somebody."

SADIE: Yes, those words kept me going.

BESSIE: This was just forty-five years after the Surrender, and most of these Negroes were in bad shape, honey. They needed help with the basics.

SADIE: You see, oftentimes, learning to read and write for the children was not the top priority. Teaching people about food preparation - like how to can food - was more important.

BESSIE: A lot of the time what those folks needed was inspiration.

SADIE: Yes, a little encouragement. That goes a long way.

BESSIE: I remember when I left home to teach. I was twenty years old. I'd never been away from home. Papa took me to the train station in Raleigh and I put on a brave front. But when that train pulled away from the station and I looked back and saw my Papa standing there, watching me, I thought I was going to die. I started to sob. I cried so hard that the people from the white car came to the colored car to get a look at this little darky just carrying on! Well, I'm embarrassed to say I created quite a commotion. The conductor came along and said, "What's the matter, did somebody die?" Now what'd he have to go and say that for? It was my girlhood that was dying and I knew it.

SADIE: Well it turned out you were the most exciting thing to happen to Boardman, North Carolina, in about a hundred years. Child, they'd never seen the likes of her! She'd walk through that town and the colored men would just stop and stare. They wouldn't say a word, they'd just take off their hats when she walked by.

BESSIE: *(Laughs.)* One time, I turned and said, 'Just what are you looking at?" They didn't answer. Finally, one of them said, "Why Miss Delany, we can't help it; you look just like a slice of Heaven." And I said, "Well, I ain't *your* slice of Heaven, so put your eyes back in yo' *head.* *(Beat)* We are not old maids. We are maiden ladies.

SADIE: Well, whatever we are, I have no regrets about it. I've had a good life, child . . . *(thoughtful beat)* Remember, it was on your way to your job in

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Brunswick - you came close to being lynched -

BESSIE: Oh, yes . . . that's right. I had to change trains in Waycross, Georgia. I was sitting in the little colored waiting room at the station, and I took my hair down and was combing it.

SADIE: She had hair down to *here.* *(She indicates her knee.)*

BESSIE: I was fixing myself up. I was going to my new job, and I wanted to look nice. There was no one in there except me and two colored teachers from New York who were traveling with me to Brunswick.

SADIE: So, there she was with her long hair down when this white man opened the door to the colored waiting room.

BESSIE: The white man stuck his head in and started, well, leering at me. He was drunk, and he smelled bad, and he started mumbling things. And I said, "Oh, why don't you shut up and go wait with your own kind in the white waiting room?"

SADIE: *(Overlapping.)* hmmmm . . . hmmmmmm . . . hm ... hmmmmmm . . . hmmmmmmm . . .

BESSIE: He slammed the door and I could hear him shouting at the top of his lungs outside, "The nigger bitch insulted me! The nigger bitch insulted me!"

SADIE: The two colored teachers slipped out the back and made a beeline for the woods.

BESSIE: Yes! They hid in the woods! I guess I can't blame them. Well, I could see a crowd begin to gather on the platform, and I knew I was in big trouble.

SADIE: Papa always said, "If you see a crowd, you go the other way."

BESSIE: I was just waiting for somebody to get a rope. Thousands of Negroes had been lynched for far less than what I had just done. But I just continued to sit on the bench, combing my hair, while that white man was a-carrying on! You see, if you act real scared, sometimes that spurs them on. Two things saved me: that glorious, blessed train rounded the bend, breaking up the crowd and giving me my way to get on out of there. And it helped that the white man was drunk as a skunk, and that turned off some of the white people. But I wasn't afraid to die! I know you ain't got to die but once, and it seemed as good a reason to die as any. I was ready. Lord, help me, I was ready.

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SADIE: You were a *fool* to provoke that white man. You should have ignored him.

BESSIE: How do you ignore some drunk, smelly white man treating you like trash?

SADIE: Sometimes, it's better to put up with it, and live to tell about it. At the very least you should have run off into the woods with those other two teachers.

BESSIE: *(To the audience.)* I told you: I would rather *die* than back down, honey . . .

SADIE: You are lucky to be alive.

BESSIE: *(After a beat)* Sadie! You know what I've been thinking lately? All those people who were mean to us in our lives . . . Why, they've turned to dust, and here we are –

BESSIE AND SADIE: *(Togther)* Still here!

BESSIE: They're turning in their graves while me and sweet sister Sadie are getting the last word . . . We're having our say, giving our opinion.

SADIE: Lord ain't it good to be an American.

BESSIE: I'll tell you a little secret: I'm starting to feel optimistic. Maybe I'll get into Heaven after all. I do have some redeeming qualities. I may have to hang on to Sadie's heels, but I'll get there.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Emily Mann
ISBN: 978-0822215028
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): May 1997

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
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